Introduction: Eastern Europeans Descend on the West

Ruairi seemed rather lonely. In the Superquinn supermarket, in a wealthy Dublin suburb on a Saturday morning in the spring of 2005, he was one of the few Irish staff at the checkout. The girl serving us was from Lithuania, and my wife and I were also from what is described as Eastern Europe. The night before, we had had dinner in a Lebanese restaurant with a Slovakian couple. The two waitresses were Polish and the belly dancer was German, presumably former East German.

Within a couple of years since May 2004, the day of the EU accession of eight new Central European (and two southern European) member states, several hundred thousands of workers from these countries came to seek work in Ireland. The decision of the Irish government to end the system of work-permits for workers from new member states was hailed by the opposition, business and trade unions alike as a way of securing much needed extra labour for what was then called the Celtic Tiger. That was, of course, before the global financial crisis of 2007.

Apart from Ireland, only the UK opened its labour market equally generously in 2004. In the period from May 2004 to March 2007, some 630,000 people from the eight accession states sought work in the UK.[2] This may seem a lot but, in proportion to the population, the figures for Ireland were even more impressive. Furthermore, the UK has for some time been a desired destination for foreign job seekers, and has traditionally been (at least in the cities) a multicultural society, so a couple of hundred thousand Eastern Europeans should not have represented a major challenge. (At least this is what most people thought before Brexit.) Other EU countries' job markets only followed after the so-called transition periods for the free movement of labour.

The Irish experience, however, has been quite different. Immigration there was a quite recent phenomenon and had come only a generation (or less) after Ireland began to recover from its own brain- and youth-drain. For centuries, Ireland used to be a country of emigration. 'Nobody ever wanted to come here', the Irish say. On the contrary, people just did not know how